American Red Cross
Southeastern Pennsylvania

Supporting

Military-Connected Clients

Job Tool for the Southeastern Pennsylvania Region

For Internal Use Only

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Purpose

The purpose of this Job tool is to familiarize the Southeastern Pennsylvania Region (SEPA) Disaster Cycle Servies (DCS) Workforce with the unique culture of the United States (U.S.) Military. This includes active duty and veterans, along with their families that reside in our region that we may serve.

How to use this Job Tool

This document is designed to make it easy for you to access the relevant information you need to support our clients. It is designed to support all Red Cross volunteers and staff, by providing information on 'who' is a military-connected individual, common greetings, a review of the military branches, and specific information on veterans.

Sections are designed to be relevant to the role you are working in.

- For **DAT, Sheltering, SRT and Casework**, there is a section on our technology – both SCIA and RC Care – and the importance of the unique data fields related to our military-connected clients.
- For **SRT and Casework**, there is a section on how to support clients through government and non-government referrals.

No matter your role, our hope is that this information helps you feel more enabled to support this important part of our community.

Who is considered military-connected?

Military-connected clients are individuals who are:

- Active duty or reservists with the U.S. Military,
- Retired from military service,
- A military veteran,
- A military dependent (can include a parent, grandparent, former spouse, sibling, or a disabled older adult),
- Military family member.

A Good Hello

The U.S. Military has six Service Branches: **Army, Navy, Marine Corps', Air Force, Coast Guard, and Space Force**. Each military Service is additionally organized to perform specialized roles. These roles determine the types of missions assigned (**See Appendix A**).

Getting to know our military-connected clients can simply begin by asking:

"**What branch of service are/were you in**?"

- By asking this question, it shows that you know there is a difference.
- Don't need to know all the specifics of each branch, most important to know that there are differences within each branch and not to generalize.

"**What is/was your occupation**?"

- There are literally hundreds of roles performed in military service.
- This question acknowledges and validates their work.
- Ask what a person does/did in the military, it matters.

A Simple Word of Thanks

"Thank You for Your Service"

This is a simple and meaningful gesture to all who serve or have served. You will witness the military-connected community thanking each other for their service. For citizens, it's an important way of acknowledging the sacrifices made that we will never know or understand. For civilians, it is acceptable to say at any stage of your conversation.

Military Veterans -What they want you to know

PsychArmor (Home - Psycharmor) asked hundreds of Veterans what they wanted civilians, employers, educators, healthcare providers, and therapists to know about them. These comments were used to create the 15 Facts that promote greater understanding of our Veterans. These are important resources to gain a better understanding of how best to work with our military veteran clients:

- YouTubeVideo 15 Things Veterans Want You to Know
- PDF Document PsychArmor 15 Things Veterans Want You to Know (**See Appendix B**)

SCIA and RC Care

Did you know that our military-connected clients may have access to unique support services?

How can you help them gain access? Ask and document in SCIA and RC Care

What to ask? The following section will help you understand what to ask.

What happens next? SRT and Caseworkers use the information to help our military-connected clients gain access to these unique support services.

Military-connected information is collected to support both our Regional Caseworkers and the Shelter Resident Transition (SRT) Team with information that will help inform their discussions with our clients.

What to Ask

In SCIA and RC Care, within the 'Demographics' section, you are going to find the questions related to "Military Status" or "Military Affiliation". It is the same question with similar drop-down selections to choose from:

SCIA: in Demographics	RC Care: in Demographics
Q: What is your military service status?	**Q: Military Affiliation?**
Not Applicable	Not Applicable
Decline to Answer	Active Duty
Active Duty	Reserve or National Guard on Active Duty
Reserve or National Guard on Active Duty	Veteran
Veteran	Retired
Retired	National Guard
National Guard	Military Dependent
Reserve	Reserve
Military Dependent	Decline to Answer
Military/Veteran Caregiver	
Listing of options are different between the two systems; definitions are the same. Military/Veteran Caregiver is not included in RC Care military affiliation question.	

Note: At this time, the data captured in SCIA under Military Service Status is not transferred to RC Care and will need to be repopulated by SRT or caseworkers.

Active Duty

- Ask if the client is active-duty military.
- The client may respond that they are active-duty Reserve or National Guard.
    - Be aware of the SCIA and RC Care drop-down answers that will need clarification:
        - Active Duty
        - Reserve or National Guard on Active Duty
    - Note: SEPA will rarely have clients in these two options.

Reserve and National Guard

- You will see in SCIA and RC Care, individual selections for each of these roles.
- In SEPA we can expect to see both roles represented in our client base.

Veteran or Retired

- Military Veterans and Military Retired are the most common military-connected individuals we will have as clients in SEPA.
- To make it easy, you can ask if the client is Military Veterans or Military Retired at the same time.

Military Dependent

- Also common in SEPA. Legal dependents are normally spouses and children. It can also include a *parent, grandparent, former spouse, sibling, or a disabled older adul*t.

Military/Veteran Caregiver

- Military/Veteran Caregivers are 1) individuals caring for Military Veterans, or 2) Military Veterans caring for non-veterans.
- The people who fill this role include Spouses/Partners, Parents, Siblings, Children, and Family members
- In **SCIA**: There is a drop-down item for Military/Veteran Caregiver
    - If the client is a Military Veteran caring for a non-veteran, select “veteran” in the drop-down. Add a note in case comments that they are a caregiver.
- In **RC Care**: there is no Military/Veteran Caregiver in the drop-down menu. Add note in Case Comments for our SEPA caseworkers

Decline to Answer

This item on the drop-down menu should be used for clients who specifically state they don’t want to answer this question. This is important for Caseworkers to know.

For more information: See Appendix C: Understanding Military Service Status

Providing Support- SRT and Casework

Important information about this community:

- Housing and Food Insecurity is a reality in active-duty, retired and veteran communities.
- According to Feeding America, 1 in 9 working age veterans are food insecure and 1.2M low-income veterans use SNAP (aka food stamps)

Military Benefits

- Military benefits are **unique to each individual**. Clients are best served by encouraging them to contact federal, state or local service centers that specialize in access and review of their benefits (*see Pennsylvania Information below*). Benefits are available to veterans who were Honorably Discharged.
- The U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) benefits and claims information and assistance can also be obtained through the **national toll free** # (800) 827-1000, TDD (800) 829-4833.

Pennsylvania Specific Information

Pennsylvania Department of Military and Veterans Affairs (DMVA)

Anyone needing help in locating their military documentation can call DMVA at 800-547-2838 or email RA-REQ@pa.gov.

SEPA County Level Support

County Directors of Veterans Affairs

A County Veterans Affairs Director is a public official who serves as the local point of contact for veterans and their families within a county. County Veterans Affairs Directors are trusted advisors who:

- Provide direct assistance to veterans and dependents in identifying, determining eligibility for, and preparing applications for county, state, and federal veterans benefits and programs.
- Serve as a liaison between veterans and government agencies, helping navigate the VA system and other benefit programs.
- Offer free, non-profit services — they never charge veterans for their assistance.
- Help veterans re-reverify their benefits or eligibility status over time.

Contact information for County Directors:

- Bucks: https://www.buckscounty.gov/directory.aspx?did=87
- Chester: https://www.chesco.org/155/Veterans-Affairs
- Delaware: https://www.delcopa.gov/department-military-and-veterans-affairs
- Montgomery: https://www.montgomerycountypa.gov/266/Veteran-Services
- Philadelphia: https://phlcouncil.com/veterans/contact-us/

Veterans Service Officers (VSOs)

VSOs assist veterans in navigating the VA benefits system, helping with claims, appeals, and accessing various services. VSOs provide:

- Claims Assistance: VSOs help veterans write and submit claims for benefits to the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA). They provide guidance on gathering necessary documentation and tracking claims through the system.
- Free Services: The services provided by VSOs are free of charge, ensuring that veterans can access support without financial barriers.
- Appeals Support: If a claim is denied, VSOs can assist veterans in filing appeals, helping to avoid delays caused by incomplete paperwork or errors in the claims process.

VSO Contacts:

- **The Veterans Multi-Service Center**: https://www.vmcenter.org/
  - Services include housing program support.
- American Legion, Veterans of Foreign Wars, AMVETS, Disabled American Veterans: If client is *a member* of these organizations, have them contact their local chapter for support. Note: these organizations may have financial aid for members who need disaster support.

Veterans Temporary Assistance (VTA) Program

- The DMVA administers the VTA program which provides temporary financial assistance up to $1,600 for necessities including food, shelter, fuel and clothing within a 12-month period to eligible veterans and their beneficiaries who reside in Pennsylvania. Veterans interested in applying for a VTA grant should contact the **County Director of Veterans Affairs** (see above) within the county where they reside.

Pre-Disaster and Post-Disaster Veterans

In the Red Cross, we use two ways to define Homeless: **Pre-Disaster Homeless** and **Post-Disaster Homeless**.

- **Post-Disaster Homeless:** For veterans who have lost housing due to a disaster, these clients should contact the *National Call Center for Homeless Veterans* at (877) 4AID-VET (877-424-3838). Clients will be routed to local resources for assistance.
- **Pre-Disaster Homeless Veterans:** The Red Cross will collaborate with the local veteran organizations for support. Discuss these clients with your supervisor.

VA Medical Centers Pre-disaster Homeless Support

- Most local VA Medical Centers have a specialized team focused on serving Pre-disaster Homeless Veterans
- The VA visit homeless encampments to identify new homeless veterans and to maintain contact with previously identified individuals.
- Veteran **autonomy and dignity** are critical to their work. They work with these veterans on the veterans' terms with the goal of finding safe long-term housing solutions.
- In addition, The VA works with Community Resource and Referral Centers (CRRCs) and other non-profit community organizations to provide wrap around services.
    - In SEPA, the CRRC is The Veterans Multi-Service Center: 215-222-7465
- Again, discuss these clients with your supervisor before contacting any organization.

Additional Resources

- Veterans who receive healthcare through VA Medical Centers are provided with team-based care referred to as a **PACT (Patient Aligned Care Team)**. The PACT includes a **Social Worker** that can also assist with recovery.
- **Legal Aid of Southeastern PA** has a **Veterans Unit**. Contact Legal Aid Veterans Advocacy Helpline: 610-283-0884 or Veterans — Legal Aid of Southeastern Pennsylvania
- The VA provides guidance on how to continue to receive VA benefits and health care when impacted by a natural disaster. Information can be found here: **VA National Disaster Support**, visit VA's Disaster Help.
- **TAPS** provides compassionate care and comprehensive resources to all those grieving a death in the military or veteran community. Mission of TAPS

The American Red Cross, Service to the Armed Forces (SAF) Resources

Hero Care Network

- Custom **Hero Care resource directory**: https://herocare.findhelp.com/
- **Emergency Communication Services** for families needing to contact **active-duty service members**: Hero Care Center at 877-272-7337.

For more information on the Hero Care Network: Hero Care Network | Service to the Armed Forces | American Red Cross

Peer Support Groups

- **Military & Veteran Caregiver Network (MVCN)** is a virtual program serving caregivers (and caregiver survivors) of all eras, stages of life, and relations, across all locations and is a resource you can provide to your client. Red Cross includes 'Veterans caring for Non-veterans' in the MVCN program (the VA caregiver program does not support these individuals).
  - Military and Veteran Caregiver Network Flyer - OneSource
  - Military and Veteran Caregiver Network | American Red Cross

- **Military 2 Veteran Network (M2VN)** – **Launching Fall 2026**. For active-duty service members and veterans. Designed to decrease isolation and increase service member and veteran connections, engagement, knowledge, skills, and hope.
  - Military 2 Veteran Network - OneSource

Additional Resources

Financial Resources:
https://sway.cloud.microsoft/flDEUBO5Ql29v1Fx?ref=Link&loc=mysways

Mental Health Resources:
https://sway.cloud.microsoft/wvKKxY7rbvBGyprj?ref=Link&loc=play

Appendix A: U.S. Military Service Branches

The U.S. Military has six Service Branches: **Army, Navy, Marine Corps, Air Force, Coast Guard, and Space Force**. Each military Service is additionally organized to perform specialized roles. These roles determine the types of missions assigned.

U.S. Army

- The Army is the oldest and largest of the military services and represents the main ground force for the United States, having been formed in the Spring of 1775.
- Core Values: Loyalty, Duty, Respect, Selfless Service, Honor, Integrity and Personal Courage
- Enlisted are referred to as **Soldiers**. Their Military Occupational Specialty (MOS) describes their occupation.
- Installations: referred to as posts, and named like 'Fort Huachuca'
- Organization: Is organized in squads, platoons, companies, battalions, brigades, divisions, corps and Armies. It has a National Guard component.

U.S. Navy (USN)

- The Navy is the second largest and second oldest branch of service, having been formed in the Fall of 1775. Its principal role is to maintain freedom of the seas.
- Core Values: Honor, Courage, and Commitment
- Enlisted are referred to as **Sailors**. The Navy Enlisted Classification (NEC) describes their occupation.
- Installations: referred to as bases or stations, and named like Oceana Naval Air Station', 'Norfolk Naval Base', or 'Saratoga Springs Naval Support Activity'
- Organization: The Navy has a wide variety of units and organizations to include ships, naval bases, naval air bases, and land-based support units
- In addition, the Navy also plays an essential role in augmenting air power and transporting Marines to areas of conflict. Navy also provides logistics, medical services, and chaplains to the Marine Corps.

U.S. Marine Corps (USMC)

- The Marine Corps is the smallest branch of service and is a component of the Dept. of the Navy, but it acts operationally as a separate branch of the military.
- USMC principal role is to conduct amphibious operations and develop amphibious doctrine. It is also tasked to protect vital naval shore facilities and U.S. government property, including Camp David and American embassies.
- Core Values: Honor, Courage, and Commitment
- Enlisted are referred to as **Marines**. Their Military Occupational Specialty (MOS) describes their occupation.

- Installations: referred to as bases, and named like ‘Camp Lejeune’
- Organization: Is organized in teams, squads, platoons, companies, battalions, regiments and divisions (similar to the Army)

U.S. Air Force (USAF)

- The Air Force principal role is to defend the country from air, space, or cyberspace threats.
- Core values: Integrity First, Service Before Self, and Excellence In All We Do
- Enlisted are referred to as **Airmen**. Their Air Force Specialty Code (AFSC) describes their occupation.
- Installations: referred to as bases, and named like ‘Tinker Air Force Base”
- Organization: Is organized in flights, squadrons, groups, wings, numbered Air Forces and Major Commands. Has a National Guard component

U.S. Coast Guard (USCG)

- The Coast Guard's principal role is to protect and secure U.S. ports and harbors. By memorandum of agreement, it provides direct support to Department of Defense (DoD) and, in wartime, may be transferred to serve in the Navy Department.
- The Coast Guard is an armed force but differs from the rest as it is not a part of the Department of Defense but instead falls within the Department of Homeland Security.
- Core Values: Honor, Respect, Devotion to Duty
- Enlisted are referred to as **Coast Guardsmen**. Their Rating describes their occupation.
- Installations: Referred to as stations and named like ‘Coast Guard Station Cape Charles’
- Organization: Consists of ships, boats, cutters, aircraft and shore stations.

U.S. Space Force (USSF)

- USSF was established on December 20, 2019. It is organized as part of the Department of the Air Force, with a mission to Secure our Nation's interests in, from, and to space.
- Core values: Character, Connection, Commitment, and Courage
- Enlisted are referred to a **Guardians**, and their Military Occupational Specialty (MOS) describes their occupation.
- Installations: referred to as bases, some installations are still called "Air Force Base", although operated by the US Space Force
- Organization: including the Space Staff, the field commands, space deltas, and squadrons.

Appendix B: 15 Things Veterans Want You to Know

1. **We are not all soldiers**
    - Each branch of U.S. Military has their own mission
    - Each has different services, different ranking, different uniforms, and perform difference missions expertly
    - Each have their own 'mini-culture'
    - Only Army personnel are soldiers
    - Need to state "military personnel" or "veterans" as reference, and not generalize all as "soldiers"

2. **Reserves are part of the military**
    - There are two ways to serve in uniform in our country
    - **Active-duty**: full-time job is to serve in the active-duty forces of the military
    - **Reserves**: are trained to serve and have day-to-day civilian jobs; may have previously served as active duty
        - Training includes:
            - 1 weekend per month
            - 2 weeks per year
        - Remain ready and serve together as a unit
        - Mobilized as needed
        - Can be disruptive to work and family life
        - Often don't have the resources and support when return back from missions as active-duty military personnel
        - 5 branches of the military have reserves (U.S. Space Force does not)
        - Some military personnel make the choice to stay in the reserves after leaving active duty to stay ready and remain in the military
        - Have their own unique challenges since living day to day as a civilian, then can have an immediate and abrupt change to their life, then return back to their community where they may not be understood
    - Both Active-Duty and the Reserves balance and complement each other

3. **Not everyone in the military is infantry (in tanks, on patrol, etc.)**
    - In 2024, active-duty is made up of 1.27 million Americans; Reserves have 750+ thousand.
    - Range from infantry to technicians, mechanics, cooks, administrators, lawyers, doctors, musicians.
    - Expertly trained for months and years to get specialty ratings.
    - Jobs have different physical and mental requirements and demands.

4. **Military has leaders at every level in the chain of command**
    - Different rank structure in all branches.
    - Leadership in place at every different level.
    - Military culture prides itself on this.
    - Responsible and accountable for others is what gives pride.
    - Less important to know what rank that person was, most important to know the person followed orders and was responsible for other.

5. **Military is always on duty**
    - Live their work 24/7.
    - Readiness is a full time, around the clock job.
    - Takes its toll on military personnel and their families. There is no off day.
    - Even when on leave, can be called immediately, at a moment's notice.

6. **Take pride in appearance and conduct**
    - All military services have standards for the way people look in uniform.
    - Takes physical fitness seriously.
    - Held to a standard of conduct and are held accountable.

7. **We did all not all kill someone**
    - Those who have do NOT want to talk about it.
    - This is a question that **should not be asked**, **EVER**.

8. **We do not all have Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)**
    - Combat can be traumatic and can cause PTSD that may require treatment.
    - PTSD can occur with normal people who have lived through something horrible and need help.
    - PTSD can be caused by many different types of trauma, including combat - All plays into the development of PTSD.
    - Most people who experience a trauma DO NOT go on to develop PTSD.
    - The majority have naturally recovered and are doing fine.
    - There will be individual difference in how people respond.

9. **Those of us who do have invisible wounds of war are not dangerous or violent**
    - Invisible combat wounds include:
        - Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
        - Traumatic Brain Injury (TBI)
        - Depression
        - Substance Use Disorder (SUD)
    - Invisible wounds are real – and are injuries.
    - Not mental illness or psychiatric condition.

- Deserve the same treatment as with visible injuries.
- The majority of people with invisible wounds are not prone to becoming dangerous or violent.
- Unfortunate myth has developed.
- The majority of these Veterans do not display violence.

10. **It's hard to ask for help**
    - Military has long standing history of promoting emotional and physical perfection
    - Stigma is better, invisible wounds are more validated now.
    - Just understanding that it is hard to ask for help, you are one step closer to being closer to them.

11. **Our military service changes us**
    - The military changes people. The change is permanent and that's okay.

12. **We differ in how much we identify with the military after we leave active duty**
    - How much military service is played out day-to-day is different from person to person.
    - Ask a Veteran: *How do you define yourself now? How has your military service shaped you?*
    - We integrate our military experiences in different ways.

13. **Our families serve with us**
    - The military family's experience is unique and challenging.
    - Frequent separation from loved ones.
    - Some military families move every two or three years.
    - Difficult to establish school and work employment.
    - Changing family dynamics and responsibilities.
    - Here's the good part: resilient, adaptive and flexible.
    - Stop and think about the sacrifice the families have made.

14. **We would die for each other and our country**

15. **We all made this sacrifice for one reason: to serve something more important than ourselves**
    - Defines our culture
    - Honor, Commitment and Duty…people make this choice

Appendix C: Understanding Military Service Status

When men and women volunteer to serve in the military, there are five options on the status of their service: Active-duty, Reserve, National Guard, Veteran, Retired. Note that we capture if Reserve and National Guard are on active-duty.

Active Duty

- Serve full time for at least 4 years
- Attend basic training, advanced training, and then are assigned to a unit
- The family may join the service member at advance training or at the first unit
- Most often, far from home/families and support system
- Most often located on or near an installation where a support system has been developed
- If the member remains on active duty, they can expect to move about every three to four years

Reserve and National Guard

- **Reserve:** Part-time federal service, keeps civilian life, activated for federal missions.
- **National Guard:** Part-time service with both state and federal roles, unique dual mission. Often activated for local emergencies
- Attend basic training and advanced training, and then serve in a unit close to home, one weekend a month and two weeks each summer
- Military is a "part-time job" while most maintain their full-time job/career or school in their hometown
- Subject to activation and deployments – again, families are not always as prepared or close to traditional family support/installations
- Subject to activation/deployments – often families are not close to traditional support/installations but are in their hometown
- The U.S. Space Force is the only Service Branch that does not have a Reserve or National Guard Unit.

Veteran

- For Red Cross purposes, men and women who have served honorably in defense of their country are veterans.
- Veterans who have been in war are "combat veterans," but anyone who has served in war or peace is a "veteran" after active service
- Veterans receive benefits from the Department of Veterans Affairs (www.va.gov).
- The amount of Veterans Administration support that they qualify for will depend on many factors, including disability, length of service and area served

Note: By statute, **veteran is defined as** a "person who served in the active military, naval, air, or space service, and who was discharged or released therefrom under conditions other than dishonorable[1].

Retired

- When a service member serves at least 20 years of active duty, they can retire from the military, and they become a retiree as well as a veteran
- Some individuals will be medically retired, leaving military duty before 20 years due to physical disabilities
- A Retiree is authorized several benefits by the military to include access to health care, military aid society financial assistance and access to legal or other support services.

Additional Military-Connected Individuals

The military community also includes military families; spouses, children and other dependents which can include a parent, grandparent, former spouse, sibling, or a disabled older adult.

Military Dependent

- This individual has identified as a legal dependent of a military-connected individual.
- **Military support service may be available**

Military/Veteran Caregiver

Military/Veteran Caregivers are 1) individuals caring for Military Veterans, or 2) Military Veterans caring for non-veterans.

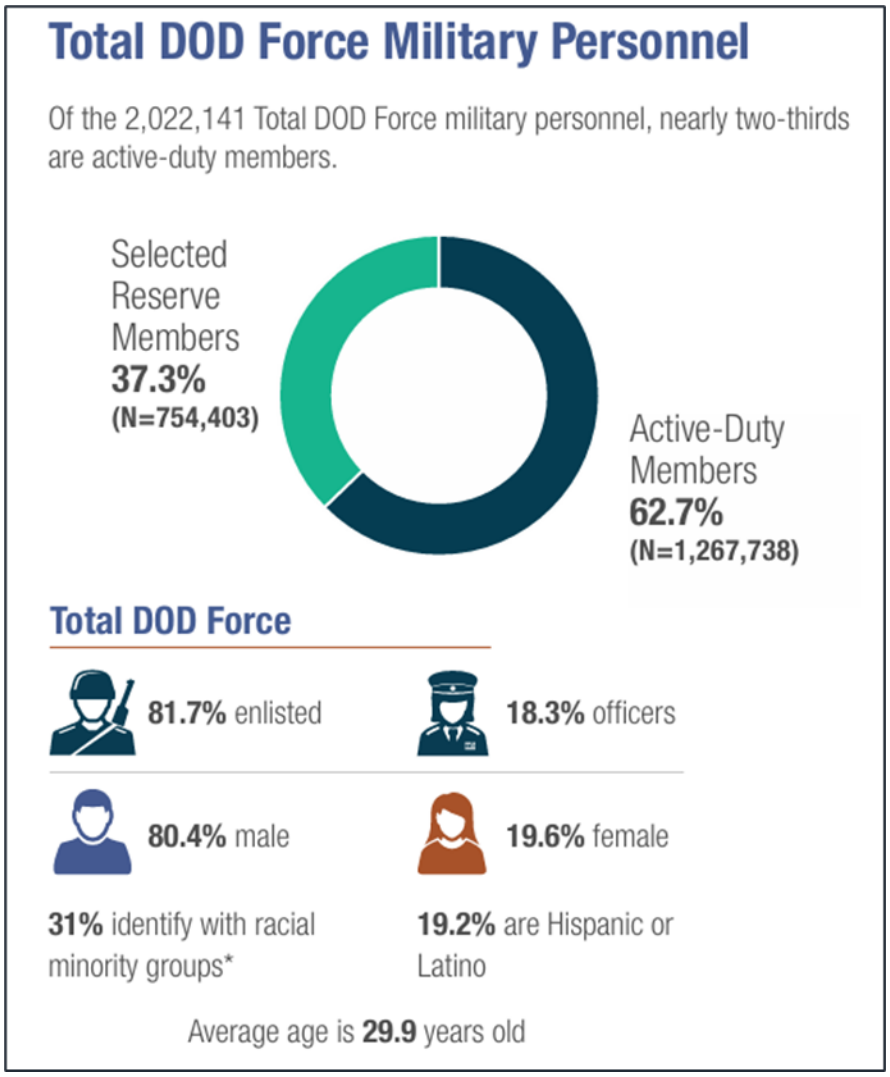
- Caregivers play a vital role in supporting the recovery, rehabilitation, and reintegration of wounded, ill, and injured military servicemembers and veterans.
- The people who fill this role includes: Spouses/partners, Parents, Siblings, Children, Family members, Friends, Battle buddies.
- The term “Caregiver Survivor” is used for individuals who are no longer caring for the individual who is now deceased.

[1] https://www.congress.gov/crs-product/R47299

Appendix D: National Military Demographics

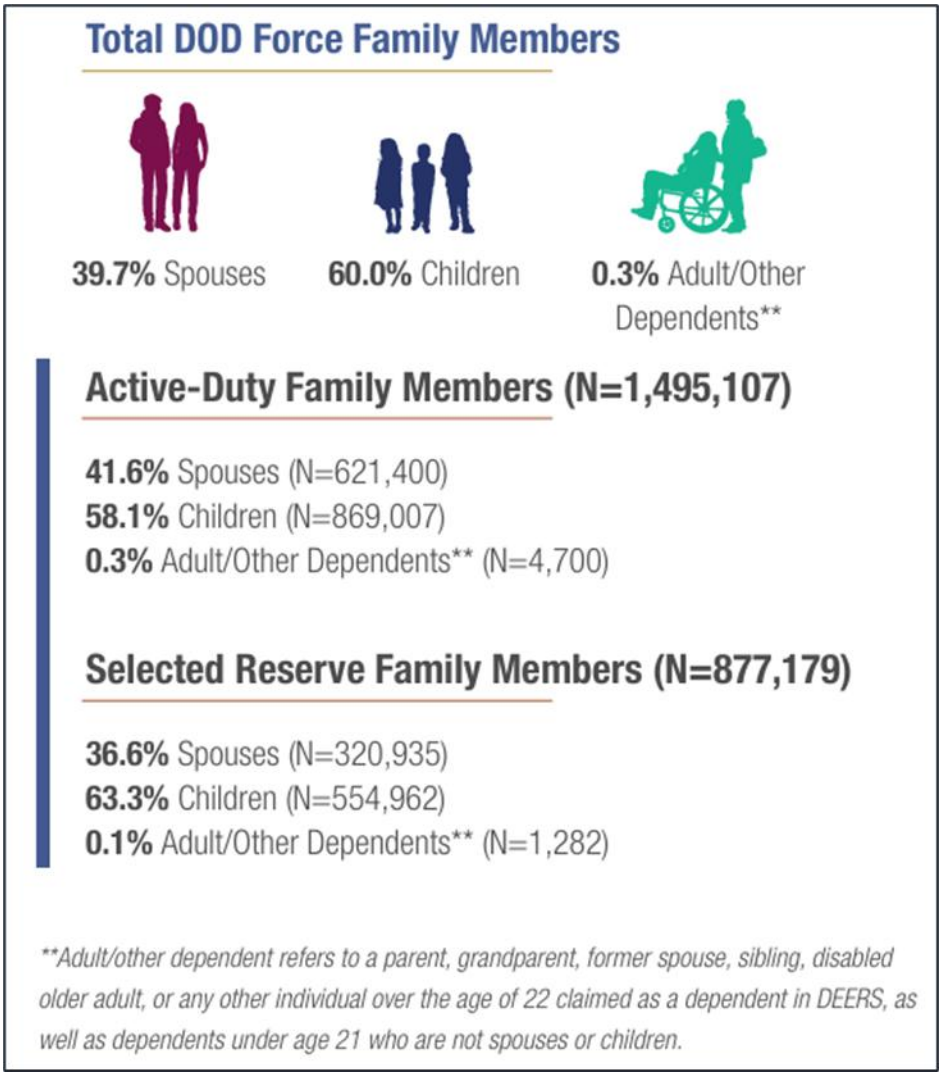
Active Duty and Reserve

In 2024 (the most recent data) there were over 4.3 million individuals who made up the total U.S. Department of Defense (DOD) Force community, including 2,022,141 (46.0%) DOD military personnel and 2,372,286 (54.0%) DOD Force family members. [2]



Of the 2,022,141 Total DOD Force military personnel, nearly two-thirds were active-duty members. Of the 2,372,286 Total DOD Force family members, 63.0% are active-duty family members.

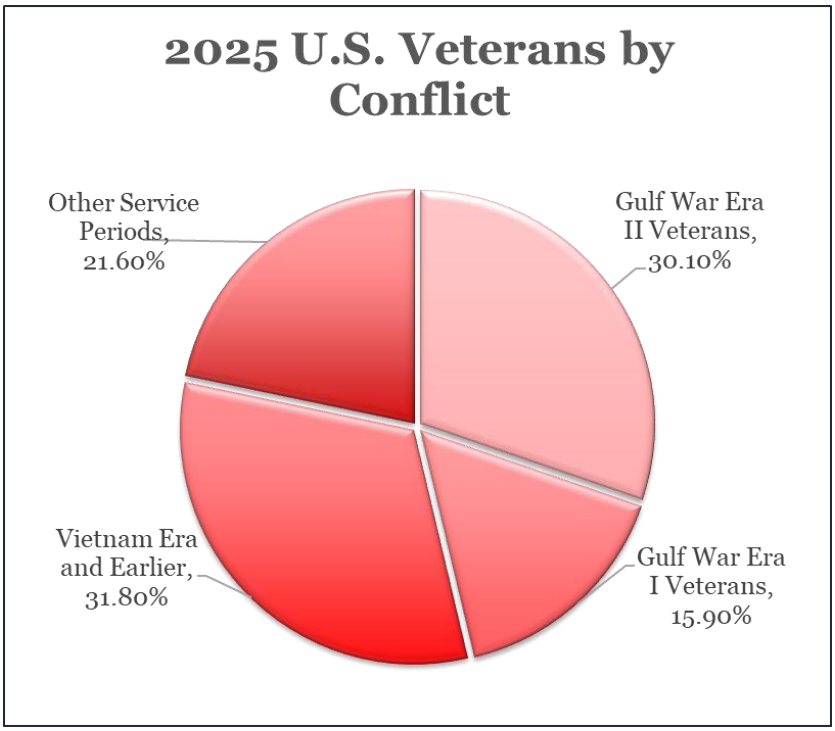
[2] 2024 Demographics Profile Members and Family



Military Veterans

According to the VA, in 2025, the United States is home to approximately 17.6 million living veterans, representing 6% of total adult population nationwide.

- One-third (5.6 million) are over age 65 from earlier conflicts
- 12% are women
- Of the 5.3 million veterans having served since September 2001 (Gulf War Era II), 48% of these recent veterans' report service-connected disabilities.



The U.S. Military has six Service Branches: Army, Navy, Marine Corps', Air Force, Coast Guard, and Space Force. Since Space Force is newer, this branch is not represented in the 2025 Veteran data set.

